

flynorse

Okay, please be aware at LAX Airport trolleys are not free. They are \$8. So please factor that in when you are into your budget for when you come to LAX.

Sometimes people have them out and you know loose, but factor in the \$8 US charge for the trolley if you are coming over to fly out of LAX in Los Angeles. Well, here we are at the priority check-in. We're here right on 1230 so that's when check-in opens and it's very easy and very fast and the line isn't really that big either for the normal check-in, which is here and this is our check-in.

So it's pretty much the same of Norse premium. So not a huge line because a lot of people get here early and we would say to you that because of the way it works with Norse premium or Norse normal you have to get here a little bit early to actually get the best the best queue experience. We're through TSA checks and we are heading now to the gate.

We can see this on the on the board. It is Norse Z0712 leaving at 4.30 p.m. And we are at gate 225 which is a long way away, but good news is there's a shuttle to get you to 225 because you don't want to walk 225 places along the way. But it's okay.

So we're heading now. We're in time. It's now about 1.30. So it's going to give us plenty of time to get to the gate and relax a little bit in the lounge or at the gate itself.

Well, here we are halfway across the Atlantic in the premium seat on Norse airlines, and I must say I'm extremely impressed. I have flown many airlines in first-class and in coach and the premium section of the North Airlines is just like first-class and many other airlines. I just had a chat with one of the pilots and the lovely Haley who is the flight attendant here in the premium capital area and the ethos of Norse Airways is that everyone is equal in the staff and that is a really good thing and you can feel the really lovely vibe here on the aircraft as you're flying along.

Everyone's happy. The staff and the attendants are extremely attentive and extremely attentive and friendly and I can't find any fault with Norse Airlines. I think it's a great airline to fly.

For a budget airline, I think it absolutely exceeds expectations and I'd be very happy to fly with them again. We are about three hours out of Gatwick on our way from LAX on this lovely flight. I started the journey at 30 p.m. from LAX and it's a 10-hour flight, but I'm definitely not feeling the plane in any way.

The selection of movies and TV shows is excellent. They have a great great selection there, so you won't be short of things to watch. And I had the salmon which was extremely fresh too, the salmon meal, which is very good too.

So yes, all in all, I'd give this flight a 9 out of 10. There were no delays at the airport. You had a

short 10-minute bus ride from check-in to Gate 225, which is the last gate at LAX, but it's such a short ride in the bus and it's pretty thrilling because you also have a lot of views of fantastic aircraft coming and going and yeah, that's great too.

You're right up close to aircraft on the way on the bus. So all in all, as I say, Travel Radio Australia gives Norse Airlines a 9 out of 10 and well, I think it's really a 10 out of 10, but, you know, I think 9 out of 10 is fair. Thank you, Norse Airlines, for such a great trip for Travel Radio Australia.

Travel Radio Australia and this month, I'm very pleased to be joined by Philip Allport, who is the Communications Manager for FlyNorse.com, which I recently travelled with from LAX, Los Angeles to London Gatwick, a 10-hour flight across the Atlantic. Philip, welcome to the programme. Thank you very much for having me on today.

Philip, can you tell us a bit about the background of FlyNorse.com? I know it's a relatively new airline. Can you tell us a bit about how it all got started? Yes, that's correct. So we are relatively new.

We only celebrated our second anniversary of flying on the 14th of June. So it's been a short but productive journey in the last two years. We started, I'd say, on a very small scale.

Our first flight was between Oslo and JFK, and our primary route network is essentially between the US and Europe. And we've slowly expanded over the last two years and slowly is really the key word. We're taking it one step at a time.

As our main destinations are all US to Europe, we serve currently six destinations from JFK to Europe this summer. And obviously Los Angeles experienced us recently as well. We fly from Los Angeles to London, Paris and Oslo seasonally.

So it's a very important market for us. But a year ago, we also branched out to Asia and we serve Oslo, Bangkok. That was our first foray going east as well.

So it's been a short journey, but as I say, we're doing it step by step. We started with one flight and here we are today with a comprehensive route network. And tell us about the routes to flynorse.com frequency between the USA and Europe.

Yep. So from the US, our main destination is the UK. So we serve Los Angeles, London, Orlando, London, Miami, London and of course, New York, London.

But beyond that, I'd say New York has Athens, Paris, Rome and Oslo added to those. So it's quite it's comprehensive that they are the focused key routes that we know travelers really want to travel between. We're not looking to create new markets.

We're not looking to take people to places they've never heard of before. These are routes that

we know the demands there. The difference is that we've come in at a very low price point.

So we are low cost. Long haul is the moniker that's been given to us, as you would have experienced the products far from the traditional low cost. But the low cost element is the unbundling of the product.

So we are giving customers a very low fare, but with the choice to add on every aspect of the product that they'd like during their journey. If you don't need to check in a bag, we won't charge you for one. If you choose not to eat, let's say on a nighttime flight travelling between JFK and London, chances are you just want to sleep.

We will not charge you for food that you may not want to eat on board the aircraft. It's about giving customers choice. And then enabling them to purchase a ticket at a low price point.

Yes, and the price of under five hundred dollars for basic fare is incredible from and that's from LAX all the way to London. And I got to you very kindly upgraded me to premium. And I must say I've travelled on first class airlines, business class airlines all over the world with my job as a travel journalist.

And it was really comparable, if not equal to many of the first class flights and business class flights that I've been on before for about a quarter of the price. You must be very proud of that. Yes, and I'd actually go beyond that.

Our premium product, which is literally called North Premium, so it keeps it simple, is actually recognized as being the number one premium product of any airline. And that's because our seat pitch and width is actually larger than any of our comparable competitors. So not only are you getting more space, more value, because the luggage is included, your meals are included as our drinks.

It's all included in the premium bundle. You're getting a product which is also better than comparable airlines. And one thing that we're very pleased about, I can talk about it now, is Skytrax, one of the most recognized world airline rating systems, voted us as the third best low cost long haul airline in the world.

Now, bearing in mind, we're obviously aiming to be number one, but this is only after two years of operation. And as you know, or some of your listeners may know, Skytrax based on actual passenger reviews and surveys. So it's something that we're very proud of, that we are new, but we're already being recognized as up and coming, certainly as a leader in the low cost long haul market.

Yes, the aircraft I've noticed is very, very clean for a low cost airline. Sometimes low cost means, you know, lower standards, but definitely is not the case at all on flynorse.com, because, yeah, it's the aircrafts are brand new. And I also noticed a vibe with the staff.

It seems that everyone's on an equal footing. Some airlines have, you know, hierarchy where people are regarded lower depending on their roles. But that doesn't seem to be the case.

I had a chat with a couple of the lovely flight attendants in premium. And they said that they what they love about the airline is that they sort of use the Scandinavian model where everyone is on an equal footing, which is really good to see and really fantastic to to see that going on. Absolutely.

I mean, we believe in a flat structure and, you know, our frontline staff, especially so the cabin crew are the people that actually see the customers. It's not people like me who sit in the offices. We rely on their feedback.

They tell us what is working on board, what is not working, what any elements of the service that should be improved. And we listen directly to our staff. They know best.

We're not the ones on board facing the customers. So we're continuously looking to improve. But at the same time, as you say, that empowerment is not something that certain other companies may be give to their employees.

And it's a very important part of our development is listen to customer feedback, but very much listen to our employee feedback who are on the front line. And that's why, as I said, you know, Skytrax is an example of this. The feedback is positive in regards to the experience.

And your cleanliness is hopefully the expectation that you'd always have when traveling because, you know, that's not always the case. But leading into that, we also have newer aircraft. I'm sure you would have noticed the aircraft are clean on the inside and the outside.

They are new. They're the Boeing 787 Dreamliners. It is a very good product in itself.

And then when you add on the service on board that you receive from our crew, we are very satisfied that we're offering one of the best ways to travel transatlanticly and long haul. Yes, I want to speak about the check in process, because unlike other airlines, you do check in at the airport. So it's best to get there as soon as the check in opens, in my case from LAX at 1230 p.m. for a 430 flight.

And then you have once you get through security, you have a short 10 minute ride from the security area to in the case of LAX to Gate 225, which is a short 10 minute bus shuttle ride. And I found it very exciting because if you're a bit of an aviation nut like me, you're right up next to the aircraft and it fills you right on the tarmac, which is quite a thrilling experience. And I suppose you have a lot of the passengers mentioning that.

Absolutely. I mean, it's a little bit of an oddity at LAX. There's not many airports where you get that experience.

However, if you want to actually be in the thick of the action and be, as you say, almost driving in between the aircraft, it's a very enjoyable experience. So, you know, we're pleased that the majority of our customers like that. And those who are less interested, it's just a short journey to to the gate, as you know.

Yes, I would definitely advise getting to the airport as early as possible to check in, get through security and take that short 10 minute bus drive in case of LAX airport. Now, Philip, what are the future expansion plans for FlyNorse.com? Well, yes, it's an open question because, you know, we are new. We do have our eyes on other destinations and other profitable routes.

But I'd have to say, watch this space. And, you know, we are looking at new things all the time. We do have new routes opening up that we've already announced for this winter.

Well, early autumn, really, only fall, which is Las Vegas to London, which is starting the 12th of September. And then we also have a very big route for us, which is our first flight into the African continent, and that's Cape Town from London as well. And obviously, you know, for customers travelling from the US, they can connect onto our flights onto Cape Town.

But it also opens up a wider European level because we do also have partnerships with other short-haul airlines around the world, allowing people to book virtual interline tickets. So you can travel from New York to London and then connect onto an easy jet flight, for example, or one of our partners onto another destination. So, you know, we are really enabling more and more people to travel.

Yes. And I suppose on the long haul flights, a lot of people get a chance to stop in at the fabulous city of Oslo, which is your base headquarters in Norway. And that's a great thing, too.

And I suppose you'd encourage people to take a little stop over there. But it's I would encourage everybody, if they can, at least once to go and visit Norway. I mean, Oslo is beautiful, but the country itself is, you know, amazing.

It is our home in the sense of that's where we were founded and that's certainly where our head office is. But it's a beautiful country. And then to the north, you know, we sell one way tickets and there's no penalty like some other airlines who sell return tickets.

And if you want a one way journey, you have to pay an exorbitant price for it. We have a one way pricing system. So there's nothing stopping you buying a one way ticket to Oslo, going to some other nice European city and then travelling back home from Rome, for example, that's the kind of thing we encourage is for people to explore and explore on a budget, spend more at the destination than you do on your flight.

I think that's the the best way to travel. Yes, 10 hours is quite a long flight from the United States, but that is all the way from LAX. So it's shorter, much shorter from New York to London, of

course, around seven, seven hours, I suppose.

But also the thing is that there's a great selection of movies and TV shows on these great little flip out screens in the seats where you get a nice big screen to watch your TV shows and movies. And it's also a little desk area that flips out on the left hand side so you can put your laptop there and work on your laptop or whatever. So it's all very well set up indeed.

I didn't really use the Wi-Fi on board. But is there any Wi-Fi on board or plans to have Wi-Fi in the future? There isn't. And at the moment, we're not planning to introduce Wi-Fi.

And there's various reasons for that. One, it is incredibly expensive to fit. However, it is quite clear that a lot of customers actually appreciate being cut off.

I'm one of them. If I'm on a long haul flight, it's from a few moments of peace. I think you get to be disconnected.

And we have very, very few requests of people actually wishing that we had Wi-Fi on board. And to be perfectly frank, the people that wish we did wanted also to be free. And as we know, a lot of airlines, some offer, I think, a very poor service for free.

And then you have to pay quite a lot of money to get a Wi-Fi connection that works. And even then, it's not necessarily that reliable. So at the moment, we don't find a reason to invest in that at the cost that it currently is.

And that's primarily based on customer feedback. If that was to change in the future, in the sense of costs would come down. And this is from an installation, an actual switching it on purpose.

Then, yes, we would always consider it, but we don't view it as a necessity. And I think neither do our customers. Yes, well, I had no problem with the entertainment.

There's a very good selection of movies and TV shows that pass away the time very quickly. You watch three movies and you're practically there at the destination. Now, I really enjoyed the vibe of the cabin as well in the premium.

And the thing is that if you do book an economy seat and that's around under five hundred dollars, if you want to upgrade, it's only a bit more. Can you give us a bit of an update on that? There's different prices and it varies by route and time of year and things with the upgrade fee. The one thing I would advise is it's always cheaper to actually just book straight away in the class that you want to travel.

But if you should change your mind, it is cheaper to upgrade in advance. And we offer various methods. You can bid for upgrades.

You can literally just pay for an upgrade. You can do it at the airport and you can also do it on

board. And we get a lot of people who arrive on board.

You know, as always, you look left to see what you could have had. And they realize actually the product is absolutely amazing, as you know, and they choose to pay to upgrade on board. And that is a possibility.

But, you know, ideally just to secure the seats that you'd want. I'd upgrade in advance and arriving at the airport because that is the most expensive way of doing it. Good for us.

That's good for our passengers. But a lot of people, I say, do realize what they could have had when they had bought the aircraft. Yes, I was comparing prices of other airline first-class business class and economy and many other airlines from LAX to London want about fifteen hundred even for an economy seat.

So if you're spending under a thousand dollars one way for a premium seat on Fly North.com, that is a very good way of doing it. Well, Philip Allport, communications manager of Fly North.com, is there anything else you'd like to add? In my case, I thought it was a very good experience, had a wonderful experience flying premium from LAX to London. No, I didn't need I mean, you know, we came to different budgets.

Obviously, there's a different travelling budget at the front and the back of the aircraft in our premium economy. But our overarching ethos is just to offer a comfortable, good value service. And that applies to both cabins.

And I'd really give the airline a 10 out of 10. There's really nothing I could really fault it with. It was an excellent journey.

And I found it to be one of the most enjoyable business class or premium class experiences I've ever had flying around the world. Yes, the website is flynorth.com. Check it out. If you are on a budget, it's a great way to go.

And Philip Allport, thank you very much for being on the program with us. Thank you very much, Jeff. Thank you.